Ramanujan was elected, Fellow of the Royal Society on February 28, 1918. He was the youngest Indian to receive this distinguished fellowship. In October that year he became the first Indian to be elected Fellow of Trinity College, Cambridge. His achievements at Cambridge include the Hardy-Ramanujan-Littlewood circle method in number theory, Roger-Ramanujan's identities in partition of integers, a long list of the highest composite numbers, besides work on the number theory and the algebra of inequalities. In algebra his work on continued fractions is considered to be equal in importance to that of great mathematicians like Leonard Euler and Jacobi.

While Ramanujan continued his research work, Tuberculosis, then an incurable disease, was devouring him. Ramanujan was sent back to India and when he disembarked, his friends found him pale, exhausted and emaciated. To forget the agonising pain, he continued to play with numbers even on his death bed.

Besides being a mathematician, Ramanujan was an astrologer of repute and a good speaker. He used to give lectures on subjects like "God, Zero and Infinity".

Glossary

EHNP9B

absurd (adj.) - stupid and unreasonable, silly in a humorous way

infinity (n) - unlimited space, time, amount, a number large beyond any limit

intriguing (adj.) - very interesting because of being unusual or mysterious

prodigy (n) - a child who shows a great ability at a young age

dingy (adj.) - a dark and dirty place

Physiology (n) - the branch of biology that deal with the normal functions of living organisms and their parts

unkempt (adj.) - not neat or cared for

uncouth (adj.) - behaving in an unpleasant way

conjecture (n) - an opinion or conclusion formed on the basis of incomplete information.

discrepancy (n) - an illogical or surprising lack of compatibility or similarity between two or more facts

distinguished (adj.) - used to describe a person, respected and admired for excellence

devouring (adj.) - destructively consuming

disembark (v) - to leave a ship, aircraft, etc. after a journey

emaciated (adj.) - very thin and weak, usually because of illness or extreme hunger

agonising (adj.) - causing extreme physical or mental pain

Book 1.indb 155 21-01-2020 17:29:14